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Forgiving Those Who Hurt You

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Forgiving Those Who Hurt You

Today's Reading: John 13:12-20

Hearing God's Voice for Today:

"I am not speaking of all of you; I know whom I have chosen. But the Scripture will be fulfilled, 'He who ate my bread has lifted his heel against me.'"

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Jesus was instructing his disciples about faithfulness. But he wanted them to realize that even though he had chosen all twelve of them, there was one who would not be faithful. He would betray Jesus. His name was Judas.

Have you ever been betrayed? Has someone hurt you deeply through lies, deceptions, and behind-the-scenes manipulations?

Most people have experienced this crucible. Some of them were great men of faith. For example, Moses faced a rebellion led by Korah. King David experienced betrayal on two different occasions by two different people. The first time was Ahithophel—a close friend and advisor. The second occurred through his son Absalom. The apostle Paul was betrayed by Alexander the Coppersmith and Demas.

It happened to Jesus as well. He wasn't surprised. Scripture had to be fulfilled (Psalm 41:9). But it still stung and scorched him. He loved Judas. He had made him treasurer over all money given to the disciples. This was not a small amount to oversee. Some widows gave significant money to fund Jesus' ministry. Judas had an important responsibility. Sadly, he failed the Lord.

Is there someone in your life who has betrayed and hurt you? If so, Jesus can empathize with the hurt in your heart. But you must not allow bitterness to eat away at your soul. It is a root that can defile you and many who live around you. It can choke away the Lord's grace and mercy.

If you cling to bitterness, you are the one eventually hurt the most. It's like drinking arsenic and expecting the other person to die. You repeatedly pay the price for another's sins against you. Sometimes this person is not even in your life anymore, and yet he continues to hurt you—even from the other side of the grave! That makes no sense.

You must forgive those who have hurt you. Refuse to hold a grudge so that the Father in heaven will forgive you. Release them to the Lord. Let him settle all debts and enact revenge. He knows all the details of what happened—much better than you do.

His justice is perfect.

If you persist in exacting revenge, Jesus will take his hands off the problem. It will become your deal. Or you can trust him and know that he will enact justice in the right way and time.

God has forgiven you a billion-dollar debt you owed him. Now forgive the person who owes you a ten-thousand-dollar debt. Let God settle the score.

In so doing, you are then released from the prison of your bitterness— and set free to live for the Lord.

[from *“Hearing the Voice of God”* by Pastor David Chadwick, Moments of Hope Church, Charlotte, NC]